

Caste Iron

Because she is a serious contender for the prime ministership after E-2009, emerging as the new political nucleus for an anti-Congress as well as anti-BJP front with the Left's support, and may win over 40 Lok Sabha seats this time even though her party won only 19 in the last elections.

Because she can play spoiler to her arch rivals, the Congress and Samajwadi Party, even outside Uttar Pradesh.

MAYAWATI

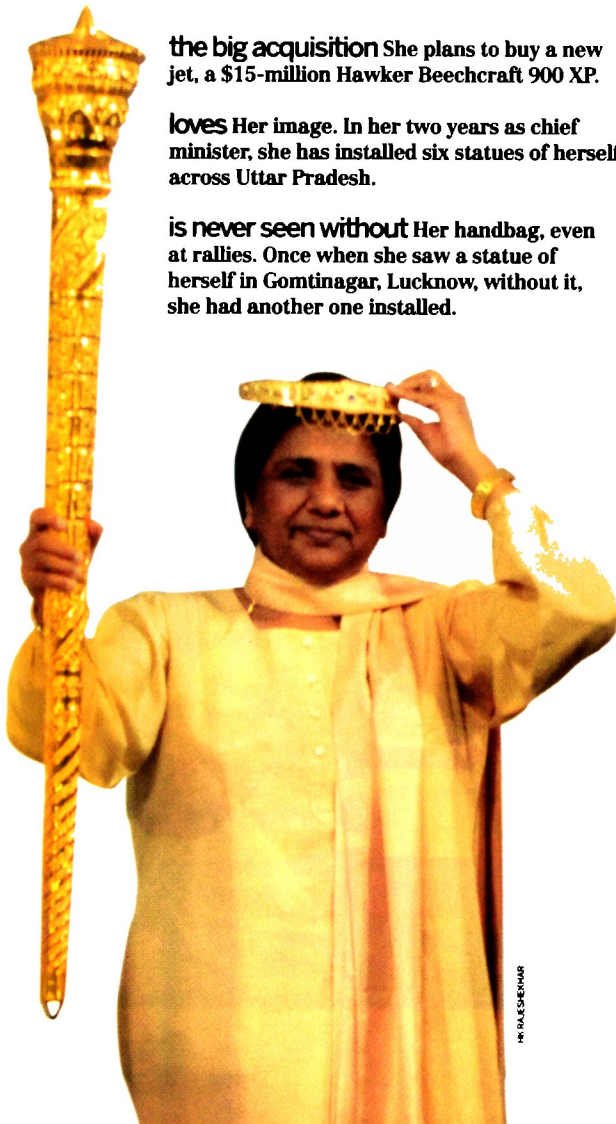
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53, Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh 4

the big acquisition She plans to buy a new jet, a \$15-million Hawker Beechcraft 900 XP.

loves Her image. In her two years as chief minister, she has installed six statues of herself across Uttar Pradesh.

is never seen without Her handbag, even at rallies. Once when she saw a statue of herself in Gontinagar, Lucknow, without it, she had another one installed.



IN PALLADIUM

The Roller Coaster

Because he will be the BJP's prime ministerial candidate one day, having become the party's star campaigner and mascot for its pin-up issue, the anti-terror plank. **Because** not just the BJP but even India Inc wants him as the prime minister. **Because** even L.K. Advani needs his help to become the prime minister.

the big acquisition Along with black polo-necks and sharp suits, he has added English to his accessories.

smart move Bagged the Nano project for Gujarat and allotted land to the Tatas in just three days.

time off Recently watched the Naseeruddin Shah-starrer *A Wednesday* on his favourite subject, terrorism.



Backroom Boy

Because he is the one man whose advice Congress President Sonia Gandhi trusts implicitly and is politically savvy enough to keep a firm footing on the slippery grounds of coterie politics. **Because** he is the brain behind every political deal struck by the Congress, from cobbling the UPA to winning the trust vote. **Because** his house at 23 Wellington Crescent is the third most important address in the Congress, after 10 Janpath and 12 Tughlak Lane. **Because** he doesn't need an office at the party headquarters as a power accessory, yet party chief ministers have to wait for weeks to meet him.

AHMED PATEL

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59, Political Adviser to the Congress chief New



SIPRA DAS